

SHARLESH RAWAL



The principle of community living, necessary for character-building and living in a harmonious society, was diluted when the system of day-time schooling was introduced for the university. Iyengar and Khimani have made residential living compulsory for all students seeking admission. However, this has invited opposition from some teachers who found the move not in step with modern times. Many wanted to avoid the drudgery and self-sacrifice associated with accepting the true Gandhian way of life. Says Nimisha Shukla, an economics teacher: "The Vidyapith is becoming a link between Gandhian ideology and society, but the challenge lies in making everyone accept this lifestyle permanently."

Lots of changes have come about after Iyengar took over and incorporated his motto "charity begins at home" in the functioning of the institution. He continues to live in his 85 square-yard flat in Ahmedabad and still tries to travel by train. What's more is that there's no element of hypocrisy in his lifestyle and conduct, which is a signature ideology of many a Gandhian in the country.

Anil Gupta, a teacher at IIM-Ahmedabad and the chairman of National Innovation Foundation, says: "The revival of Gujarat Vidyapith comes at a very good time. Most of our initial discoveries of grassroots innovators came with the help of these Gandhian students from Vidyapith

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**"The response we are getting for our efforts is encouraging."**

SUDARSHAN IYENGAR, VICE-CHANCELLOR, GUJARAT VIDYAPITH

Iyengar, who has been an adviser to the Planning Commission panels on drought-remedial measures, says, "The response we are getting is encouraging." Some of the steps taken by the university are reviving the Gaushalas attached to colleges and reintroducing weaving with the *charkha*, which is a true form of the Gandhian ideology. Observes a confident Khimani: "There is no reason why we shouldn't succeed in our mission." Pradip Sonar, a hostel rector, adds, "After students were made to participate in all Vidyapith public programmes and forbidden from using mobile phones while studying, we expected a drop in admissions. But the admissions seem to be increasing."

colleges and institutions." The change Iyengar has brought in the institution is undeniable. Has Mukh Patel, a social worker, says: "The revival of this premier institution augurs well because Gandhism has the power to provide answers to many present-day problems, particularly those relating to economics and environment."

Keeping up with Gandhian philosophy and the lifestyle is nearly an impossible task today. Iyengar and his team have managed to find a middle ground and shown the world that Gandhi is not dead and his ideology can still be applied to solve many problems. This balancing act is very evident on Iyengar's desk—a high-end laptop placed right next to a *charkha*. ■